

Standards Alignment & Gap Analysis

Mr. B's 8th Grade U.S. History · Alderwood Middle School

Mapped to the WA Social Studies Learning Standards (2019), Grade 8 / U.S. focus · Prepared June 2026

How to use this document

This is a working planning tool, not a compliance audit. It maps every unit on your site to the Grade 8 / U.S. standards a Washington 8th-grade course is responsible for, shows where coverage is strong, light, or missing, and turns the gaps into concrete project ideas you can act on. Pair it with the interactive **Standards Progression Map** now linked in your site's navigation — that page shows how each skill stacks from 6th (World) to 7th (WA State) to 8th (U.S.), while this document focuses on the 8th-grade row you actually teach.

Coverage symbols used throughout:

- **Strong** — explicitly taught and assessed in the unit.
- ◐ **Partial / Light** — touched or implied, but not a clear focus; an easy place to deepen.
- **Gap** — a Grade 8 standard not meaningfully addressed anywhere yet.

The big picture

Your course is built on the spine of the WA 8th-grade History standard **H1.6-8.6** — U.S. history from 1763 to 1877 — and you cover its four required eras in order: Fighting for independence, Establishing the new nation, Slavery/expansion/removal/reform, and Civil War & Reconstruction. That chronological backbone is exactly what the standards ask for, and your consistent “whose story is left out?” throughline is a direct, repeated hit on the multiple-perspectives standards (**H3.6-8.4** and **H3.6-8.5**). Three strands are in strong shape: **History** (your strongest), **Civics** (Constitution, checks & balances, SCOTUS), and **Social Studies Skills** (the Revolution podcast, the Treaty of Greenville CER, and the SCOTUS debate together cover inquiry, reasoning, deliberation, and argument-with-citation).

Geography is solid through the colonial regions and westward expansion.

The headline finding: Economics is the thinnest strand, and “do-civics” (taking action on a national issue) is the single clearest gap. Both are very fixable — mostly by adding an economic lens to units you already teach (Early Republic, Civil War) and by giving your Semester 2 capstone a civic-action structure. Details and project ideas follow.

Coverage matrix: units × strands

A quick visual of how each unit contributes to each strand at the Grade 8 / U.S. level. Read down a column to see a strand's overall health; read across a row to see a unit's reach.

Unit	Civics	Econ	Geog	History	Skills
Intro — Who Are We?	◐	—	—	◐	●
1 — 13 Colonies	—	●	●	●	◐
2 — Road to Revolution	●	—	—	●	●
3 — Voices of the Revolution	●	—	—	●	●
4 — The Constitution	●	—	—	◐	◐
5 — Checks &	●	—	—	◐	●

Unit	Civics	Econ	Geog	History	Skills
Balances					
6 — SCOTUS	●	—	—	●	●
7 — The Early Republic	●	●	●	●	●
8 — Westward Expansion	●	—	●	●	●
9 — The Civil War	●	●	●	●	●
Capstones 1 & 2	●	—	—	●	●

Strand health at a glance: History ●●● Civics ●● Skills ●● Geography ● Economics ○

Unit-by-unit standards map

Specific Grade 8 / U.S. standard codes each unit addresses. Codes match the Standards Progression Map page; “Skills” codes (SSS) apply across all middle-school grades.

Unit	Standards addressed	Notes / strongest hits
Intro — Who Are We?	C1.6-8.3 · C4.6-8.4 · SSS3.6-8.1 · H4.6-8.3	Classroom Constitution is a clean C4.6-8.4 (individual rights vs. common good). Identity work sets up perspective-taking.
1 — 13 Colonies	G1.6-8.5 · G2.6-8.6 · E2.6-8.5 · E4.6-8.5 · H2.6-8.6 · H3.6-8.4 · SSS2.6-8.2	Three colonial regions = geography of place. Triangle Trade + Slave Voyages DB = economics & sourcing. Indigenous perspectives = H3.6-8.4.
2 — Road to Revolution	H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H3.6-8.4 · H3.6-8.5 · C1.6-8.3 · SSS1	“Whose story is left out?” timeline = causal analysis + perspective. DOI close read = C1.6-8.3 ideals.
3 — Voices of the Revolution	H2.6-8.6 · H3.6-8.4 · C1.6-8.4 · SSS2.6-8.1 · SSS4.6-8.1 · SSS4.6-8.2	Overlooked-figure podcast is a textbook SSS4 product (research → thesis → cite). “Freedom that doesn’t include you” = C1.6-8.4.
4 — The Constitution	C1.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.6 · C1.6-8.4 · SSS1	Convention compromises “at whose expense” = C1.6-8.4. Democracy vs. republic = C2.6-8.6. Native Nations thread links to Gr. 7 treaty standards.
5 — Checks & Balances	C2.6-8.5 · C2.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.4 · H3.6-8.4 · SSS4.6-8.1	Branch scenarios = C2.6-8.5 (checks via an event). Treaty of Greenville CER = argument + perspective on tribal fairness.
6 — SCOTUS	C2.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.5 · C1.6-8.4 · C4.6-8.4 · SSS3.6-8.1 · SSS4.6-8.1	Judicial review + landmark cases = checks & rights vs. reality. SCOTUS debate project = SSS3 deliberation.
7 — The Early Republic	H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H2.6-8.7 · C3.6-8.5 · C3.6-8.6 · G2.6-8.8(☛)	Best home for early foreign policy (C3.6-8.5/.6: War of 1812). Lewis & Clark touches expansion. Prime spot to add economics (see ideas).
8 — Westward Expansion	G2.6-8.8 · G2.6-8.6 · G1.6-8.5 · H2.6-8.6 · H3.6-8.4 · H1.6-8.6 · C3.6-8.6(☛)	Manifest Destiny = migration as growth catalyst (G2.6-8.8). Indigenous & Mexican perspectives = H3.6-8.4. Activities still “coming soon.”
9 — The Civil War	H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5/.6/.7 · H3.6-8.5 · E4.6-8.5 · E2.6-8.5(☛) · C1.6-8.4	Slavery & wealth/resources = E4.6-8.5. Sectionalism is an open door for tariff/trade economics (E2/E3/E4).
Capstones 1 & 2	SSS4.6-8.1 · SSS4.6-8.2 · H4.6-8.3(☛)	Synthesis products = SSS4. Currently “details coming soon” — ideal place to add the civic-action piece (see Project C).

Gap analysis (prioritized)

These are the Grade 8 / U.S. standards that are currently light or missing, ordered by how much instructional value you'd gain by addressing them.

Priority 1 — Economics (whole strand is thin)

Only **E4.6-8.5** (slavery, wealth, and resources in the Civil War unit) is clearly taught. These four are light or missing:

- **E3.6-8.3** — U.S. government taxation, currency, and tariffs. **(Gap)**
- **E2.6-8.6** — supply & demand in U.S. international trade. **(Gap)**
- **E4.6-8.6** — costs & benefits of U.S. trade policies. **(Gap)**
- **E1.6-8.3** — weighing profit against personal values in economic choices. **(Light — implied in the Triangle Trade simulation)**

Good news: you don't need a new unit. The Early Republic (Hamilton's financial plan, tariffs, the Whiskey Rebellion) and the Civil War (cotton economy, Tariff of Abominations, sectionalism) are natural homes — see Projects A and B.

Priority 2 — Civic action on a national issue

- **C4.6-8.5** — *employ strategies for civic involvement that address a national issue.* **(Gap)**

You teach civic knowledge thoroughly, but students don't yet *practice* civic action on a current national issue. This is the standard's "do-civics" expectation, and it pairs perfectly with the Semester 2 capstone (Project C).

Priority 3 — Geography & history-to-today connectors

- **G2.6-8.7** — cultural diffusion in the U.S. **(Light)**
- **G3.6-8.3** — using U.S. geography to understand diversity, trade, and sustainability. **(Light)**
- **G1.6-8.6** — using maps/images to explain political, cultural & economic dynamics. **(Light)**
- **H4.6-8.3** — connecting a historical event to a contemporary issue. **(Light — mostly in capstones)**

Project & next-year ideas

Each idea names the gap it closes and, where possible, builds on something already on your site. Roughly ordered from biggest payoff to quickest win.

Project A — “You’re the Treasury Secretary” — Founding an Economy (Early Republic)

Closes: E3.6-8.3, E2.6-8.6, E4.6-8.6, E1.6-8.3, H2.6-8.7

A short decision-simulation built around Hamilton’s financial plan: the national bank, assuming state debts, the first tariffs, and the whiskey tax that sparked rebellion. Students role-play cabinet advisors weighing competing economic and political interests, then defend a recommendation. This single project lands four of your five economics gaps and reinforces “technology & ideas” causation.

Builds on: the Hamilton musical study already in Unit 4 — extend that interest into the actual economic policy fights of the 1790s.

Project B — Tariffs, Cotton & Sectionalism economic lens (Civil War)

Closes: E2.6-8.5, E2.6-8.6, E4.6-8.6, H3.6-8.5

Add an explicit economic analysis to the run-up to war: the cotton economy and enslaved labor as a supply-and-demand system, the “Tariff of Abominations,” and how Northern and Southern economic interests deepened sectional conflict. Strengthens both the economics strand and your causal-argument standard about why the nation split.

Builds on: your existing Sectional Crisis reading (Ch. 13) and Civil War causation focus.

Project C — Civic Action Capstone (Semester 2)

Closes: C4.6-8.5, C4.6-8.4, H4.6-8.3, SSS3.6-8.1, SSS4.6-8.1

Replace the “coming soon” Semester 2 capstone with a civic-action project: each student picks a present-day national issue with deep historical roots from the year (voting rights, treaty rights, immigration, free expression), builds an evidence-based claim, and produces a real advocacy product — an op-ed, a letter to a representative, or a short PSA. This is the most efficient single addition in this document: it closes the biggest civics gap (C4.6-8.5), the history-to-today gap (H4.6-8.3), and gives your strong skills work a culminating home.

Builds on: the existing Capstone 2 synthesis slot and your year-long “whose voice is heard?” throughline.

Project D — Map a Changing Nation (Westward Expansion)

Closes: G1.6-8.6, G2.6-8.7, G3.6-8.3

Unit 8 currently shows “activities coming soon.” A layered-map activity — overlaying territorial growth, migration routes, Indigenous nations, and resource/trade patterns — lets students use maps to explain political, cultural, and economic dynamics, and to trace cultural diffusion as peoples meet in the West. Fills three geography gaps and a content hole at once.

Builds on: the existing Westward Expansion unit and its Indigenous/Mexican-perspective questions.

Project E — “Then & Now” unit closers (recurring routine)

Closes: H4.6-8.3 (distributed across the year)

A low-lift five-minute closer at the end of each unit: one prompt connecting that era’s event to a current issue. Spreading H4.6-8.3 across all units (instead of saving it for the capstone) builds the habit of present-relevance and gives you repeated, lightweight evidence of the standard.

Builds on: nothing new required — slots into units you already teach.

Project F — Activate 7th-grade treaty knowledge (vertical articulation)

Closes: C3.6-8.3, C3.6-8.4 (Gr. 7 prior knowledge) → C1.6-8.4, H3.6-8.4

Your students arrive from 7th-grade Washington State History, where they studied tribal treaties and treaty rights as “the supreme law of the land.” Your Treaty of Greenville CER and the Native Nations

thread in the Constitution unit are perfect moments to explicitly call back to that prior learning. A quick “remember from 7th grade...” move strengthens both the analysis and your department’s 6–7–8 coherence.

Builds on: the Treaty of Greenville CER (Unit 5) and Native Nations content (Unit 4).

Sequencing suggestion

Quick wins for this year: Projects E and F (routines/call-backs) and the profit-vs-values reflection from Project A's economics framing — all low-prep.

Bigger builds for next year: Project C (Civic Action Capstone) first — highest payoff — then Project A (Founding an Economy) and Project D (Westward maps), both of which also fill units currently marked “coming soon.”

Appendix: the Grade 8 / U.S. standard set

The full list of WA 8th-grade (U.S.-focus) standards your course is responsible for, with current coverage. ● strong
 · ◐ light · ◑ gap. Skills (SSS) apply across grades 6–8.

Code	Standard component (Grade 8 / U.S.)	Coverage
C1.6-8.3	Explain key ideals in the DOI, Constitution, and Bill of Rights.	●
C1.6-8.4	Evaluate efforts to reduce gaps between U.S. ideals and reality.	●
C2.6-8.3	Analyze the structure and powers of national government.	●
C2.6-8.4	Use knowledge of government to analyze a political issue.	●
C2.6-8.5	Evaluate the system of checks and balances based on an event.	●
C2.6-8.6	Show the U.S. government includes democracy and republic.	●
C3.6-8.5	Identify early examples of U.S. foreign policy.	●
C3.6-8.6	Analyze how the U.S. has interacted with other countries.	●
C4.6-8.4	Analyze how a claim balances individual rights and common good.	●
C4.6-8.5	Employ civic-involvement strategies on a national issue.	◑
E1.6-8.3	Analyze profit vs. personal values in economic choices.	◐
E2.6-8.5	Analyze supply & demand in U.S. production/consumption.	◐
E2.6-8.6	Analyze supply & demand in U.S. international trade.	◑
E3.6-8.3	Analyze U.S. taxation, currency creation, and tariffs.	◑
E4.6-8.5	Analyze distribution of wealth & resource sustainability in U.S.	●
E4.6-8.6	Explain costs & benefits of U.S. trade policies.	◑
G1.6-8.5	Explain physical & cultural characteristics of U.S. regions.	●
G1.6-8.6	Use maps/images to explain political, cultural & economic dynamics.	◐
G2.6-8.6	Analyze environment–people interaction in the U.S.	●
G2.6-8.7	Explain cultural diffusion in the U.S.	◐
G2.6-8.8	Explain migration as a catalyst for U.S. growth.	●
G3.6-8.3	Use U.S. geography to understand diversity, trade, sustainability.	◐
H1.6-8.6	Explain eras in U.S. history, 1763–1877 (four eras).	●
H2.6-8.5	Analyze how individuals & movements shaped U.S. history.	●
H2.6-8.6	Analyze how cultures & ethnic groups contributed.	●
H2.6-8.7	Analyze how technology & ideas impacted U.S. history.	●
H3.6-8.4	Interpret U.S. historical materials from multiple perspectives.	●
H3.6-8.5	Analyze multiple causal factors to take positions on events.	●
H4.6-8.3	Connect a U.S. historical event to a contemporary issue.	◐

Code	Standard component (Grade 8 / U.S.)	Coverage
SSS1.6-8.1/2	Analyze positions/evidence; evaluate logic of reasons.	●
SSS2.6-8.1/2	Use research questions; evaluate source credibility.	●
SSS3.6-8.1	Deliberate public issues from multiple viewpoints.	●
SSS4.6-8.1/2	Build a thesis-driven product; cite sources properly.	●

Source: *OSPI K–12 Social Studies Learning Standards (2019), Grades 6–8 — Civics, Economics, Geography, History, and Social Studies Skills strands; and the OSPI Recommended Scope & Sequence (2020), which places Grade 8 as U.S. History & Government (primarily the 19th century).*